the country will be open for daughters of the country.'[66] Admissions to the tri-services National Defence Academy in Khadakwasla, a hitherto male preserve, were also opened up to girls in October 2021, after a landmark Supreme Court order on 18 August 2021. Almost one-third of the 5,70,000 students who applied thereafter for the maiden co-educational entrance examination for National Defence Academy in November 2021, were girls (1,78,000).[67]

Earlier, in 2018, Modi had devoted the year's first episode of his *Mann Ki Baat* programme entirely to the theme of women's achievements. Reading from a letter sent to him by a certain Prakash Tripathi on the Narendra Modi app, the prime minister told viewers that 'the flight of our courageous Defence Minister Nirmala Seetharaman [then defence minister] in a Sukhoi 30 fighter plane is inspirational for him [Tripathi]. He also refers to INSV Tarini, with an all-women crew on board under the command of Vartika Joshi, which is currently circumnavigating the globe. Three braveheart women, Bhavna Kanth, Mohana Singh and Avani Chaturvedi, have become fighter pilots and are undergoing training on the Sukhoi-30. An Air India Boeing jet with an all-women crew led by Kshamata Vajpayee flew from Delhi to San Francisco, USA and back. These are all women achievers. You are absolutely right. Today women are not just advancing in myriad fields; they are leaders.' Calling them 'First Ladies', Modi went on to list a host of women breaking glass ceilings: 'the first female Merchant Navy Captain, the first female passenger train driver, the first female fire fighter, the first female Bus Driver, the first woman to set foot on Antarctica, the first woman to reach Mount Everest … Our woman power … breaking the age old shackles of social mores, creating new records.' The prime minister concluded by telling his viewers that all these details had been compiled into a book on 'first ladies' so that the 'entire country comes to know about the power of these women', and that this was now available as an eBook on the Narendra Modi website.[68] Subsuming both nation and gender, the political packaging was complete.

There is enough evidence to show that the BJP's political outreach to women is personally led by Modi. He speaks far more on the issue than his own party, the Congress or the RSS. This was starkly evident when we compared women-mentions in all Modi